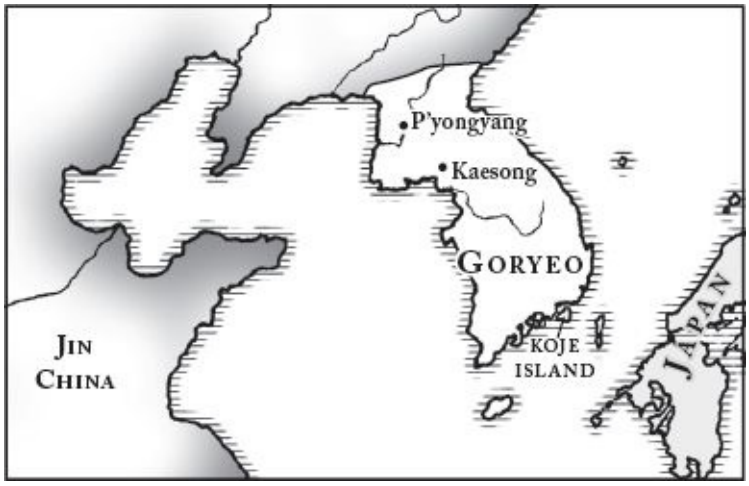


10.1 Goryeo

This did not translate into a peaceful existence.

In the early decades of the twelfth century, two major rebellions had rocked the palace; the first led by the king's own father-in-law, the second by a rebellious Buddhist monk who raised an army from his followers and labeled it the "Heaven-Sent Force of Loyalty and Righteousness." Both revolts had been put down by the reigning monarch, King Injong; but they had risen out of a deep discontent that Injong did nothing to address.[1]

Unified though it was, Goryeo was heavily scored by internal divisions. The old families, those that could trace their lineage back to the days before unification, married among themselves, held their country estates apart, and filled most of the offices of civil government: an aristocrat could always be known, remarked the twelfth-century poet Yi Kyu-bo, by "the official tablet stuck in his girdle."[2]

Military officers, on the other hand, were relegated to the lowest possible appointments. The army had served the throne loyally in putting down rebellions, and a standing force was needed to protect the northern border against wandering nomadic invaders; but the aristocracy was unwilling to allow soldiers to gain any more power. Injong's officials had even decided to do away with the exams that allowed military men to qualify for important civil posts. There was no longer any way for a soldier to rise through the ranks and gain power at court.[3]

Nor were soldiers the only victims of aristocratic ambition. Since the beginning of the century, the spread of great private estates—enlarged both by royal presents and by out-and-out confiscation of the fields of the poor—had displaced more and more of Goryeo's peasants; too many now wandered through the countryside, giving up farming for a life of banditry.[4]